electrifying.’ His hugely popular and motivating addresses, peppered with subtle humour during the Annual Group Management Meets (AGMMs) that he started after he became the Tata Sons chairman, were testimonials to his communication skills.

Perhaps Ratan himself was partly responsible for his portrayal as a placid personality. Though by the late 1980s he had spent around twenty-five years in the group and was probably the most exposed to the inner workings of the conglomerate across segments, he preferred to keep a low profile—in stark contrast to the larger-than-life personalities of the other contenders.

Ratan’s reluctance to grab the spotlight led to him often being labelled as ‘an unknown entity’ and a ‘reluctant businessman’. His appointment as chairman, Tata Sons, did not change the perception. Even after a decade at the helm, when asked if he had changed, he replied: ‘A reluctant businessman? Yes. No, it has not changed. I don’t live, sleep and every waking hour and every sleeping hour, think about business.’

As industry observers speculated on the possible successors, Bombay House did not give any clear clues to JRD’s thinking. Yet, from time to time, especially in the mid-1980s, JRD would throw hints that Ratan could also be a contender. In 1985, he gave the strongest indication of this, saying, ‘Ratan has the talent and now has been given the means to acquire the position of confidence that will show he is fit to be a leader. I would like to continue the tradition of having a Tata lead this group. But I believe that the position has to be earned.’

Another interview JRD gave in 1986 was particularly significant for the light it threw on how he viewed Ratan. When asked, ‘Why did you pick Mr Ratan Tata as your heir apparent by making him chairman of Tata Industries?’ he said, ‘Well … I think that this is a young man with modern ideas.’ Replying to a follow-up question about whether JRD thought that Ratan was ‘slipping’ into the role that JRD held as chairman, Tata Sons, his answer was more affirmative. He replied, ‘Yes. I think he’s doing what he can. He’s introducing new ideas, new strategic planning. He’s brought new business to us. And I think he’ll do well.’

By the end of the decade, the choice had evidently begun to narrow. Yet no one seemed to have been able to predict with any confidence whom JRD would ultimately choose. Many of the analysts were unable to mine some of the critical factors that weighed favourably on Ratan’s side in JRD’s mind.